Paper 3 — standalone practice paper

Independent author-written practice for Cambridge Islamic Studies 9488, October/November 2026 preparation. NOT an official Cambridge paper, leak or guarantee. The answer guidance is in 04_Practice_Papers_and_Answer_Guide.pdf.

Heritage of Islam • 1 hour 30 minutes • 50 marks

Answer **one** question from Section A and **one** from Section B. Each question totals 25 marks: (a) 10 and (b) 15. In Section A(a), use the supplied source and your own knowledge. The text sources below are original teaching descriptions, not quotations from a medieval author or substitutes for practising genuine exam images.

Section A — answer Question 1 OR Question 2

Source A: an author-written description of a mosque

A mosque occupies a site used for worship before Islam. Its courtyard opens into a large prayer hall. Reused columns and mosaic landscapes appear alongside arrangements for congregational Muslim worship. A tower makes the building visible across the city.

1(a) Explain how Umayyad architecture expressed Islamic belief while adapting earlier traditions. Refer to Source A and your own knowledge. **[10]**

1(b) “Religious policies were more important than political and economic policies to the success of the Umayyads.” Evaluate this statement. **[15]**

Source B: an author-written account of intellectual enquiry

A scholar studies an earlier account of vision. Rather than accepting the authority of its author, he compares the account with the behaviour of light passing through a small opening into a dark space. He records observations and uses mathematical reasoning to examine his

explanation.

2(a) Explain how observation and reasoning contributed to scientific achievements in the Islamic world during the Abbasid era. Refer to Source B and one scientist you have studied. **[10]**

2(b) “Openness to other traditions was the main reason for the success of Abbasid learning.” Discuss. **[15]**

Section B — answer Question 3 OR Question 4

3(a) Explain how two significant works by Muslims use different approaches to understanding Islamic beliefs. **[10]**

3(b) “Reasoning about the natural world is sufficient for explaining Islamic beliefs to people today.” Evaluate this statement. **[15]**

4(a) Explain how features of two mosques you have studied communicate Islamic beliefs. **[10]**

4(b) “Preserving traditional architecture is more important than creating new styles.” Discuss with reference to Muslim beliefs and communities. **[15]**